# Tobias Constien

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## EDUCATION

**Doctor of Philosophy (PhD),** University College Dublin **Sept 2024 – present**
Dublin, Ireland
A three-year PhD program in the UCD Babylab under the supervision of Assoc. Prof. Michelle Downes and Assoc. Prof. Brendan Rooney at the School of Psychology at University College Dublin. Funded via the UCD Ad Astra Scholarship. My research project focuses on pretend play and executive functions during the toddlerhood period.

**Masters of Psychological Science,** University College Dublin
Dublin, Ireland **Sept 2023 – Aug 2024**

- 1st Class Honours (3.94/4.00 GPA)

A one-year postgraduate program in psychology with a chosen emphasis on developmental and counselling psychology. Research project on research communication in palliative care research under the supervision of Prof. Suzanne Guerin and funded by the European Association for Palliative Care.

**Psychology (Higher Diploma),** Trinity College Dublin **Sept 2021 – May 2023**
Dublin, Ireland

- 1st Class Honours (76)

A two-year psychology conversion course that grants a pre-professional qualification in psychology. Funded by the German Academic Scholarship Foundation. Final project in the Infant and Child Research Laboratory under the supervision of Prof. Jean Quigley on parental playfulness.

**Dramatherapy (Bachelor of Arts),** Nürtingen-Geislingen University **Sept 2017 – Aug 2021**
Nürtingen, BW, Germany

- 1,1 (German Grading System)

Four-year program of drama therapy with an emphasis on psychology, counselling and the performing arts. Funded by the German Academic Scholarship Foundation and the Deutschlandstipendium. Thesis on intersectoral cooperation between the cultural sector and health services (1,0), which was awarded the Young Arts Therapies Research Award.

## RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

**Tutor and Occasional Lecturer,** School of Psychology **Sept 2025 – present**
University College Dublin, Ireland
Teaching undergraduate and graduate modules on research methods and statistics, early childhood development, and introductory courses on psychology as a tutor, and occasional lecturer. Topics include play, cognitive development, or quantitative statistics. For a full overview of my teaching and sample lectures see tinyurl.com/TobiasConstien

**Associate Data Specialist,** Childhood Development Initiative **Feb 2024 – present**
Tallaght, Dublin, Ireland
Analysing quantitative and qualitative data from early childhood and education programs from the Childhood Development Initiative as well as other organisations from the area-based childhood programme (ABC).

**Tutor and Occasional Lecturer,** School of Environment, Design and Therapy **Sept 2022 – present**
Nürtingen-Geislingen University, Germany
Developing and teaching seminars for undergraduate students in the dramatherapy program on topics in and around research in dramatherapy, which aim to foster research skills.

**Research Assistant,** Institute for Research and Development in the Arts Therapies **Sept 2021 – Aug 2024**
Nürtingen, BW, Germany
Conducting research on the literature in the field of dramatherapy and teaching tutorials in research methods to students in the undergraduate dramatherapy program. My research was published in international peer-reviewed journals and presented at international conferences in Germany, Belgium, the Netherlands, as well as the UK.

## HONOURS & AWARDS

**Presentation Award,** Best Talk — **Aug 2026**
International Conference of Infant and Early Child Development (Lancaster University)

**Postgraduate Conference Travel Award,** School of Psychology, UCD Dublin — **Aug 2026**
500€ to attend the International Conference of Infant and Early Child Development

**Best Project Award,** UNA Europa — **July 2024**
Data Science and AI Challenge for Social Welfare

**Presentation Award,** Best Lightening Talk — **Dec 2024**
Children's Research Network (Ireland)

**Travel Award,** European Association for Palliative Care — **May 2024**
2,000€ to attend the Palliative Care World Research Congress, Barcelona

**Graduates' Prize in Psychology,** Highest overall mark in graduating class — **Jun 2023**
Trinity College Dublin

**Young Arts Therapies Research Award,** Best Bachelor Thesis — **Oct 2021**
Scientific Association for the Creative Arts Therapies (WFKT)

**Scholarship,** German Academic Scholarship Foundation — **2020-2024**
300€/month, plus tuition and fees for Higher Diploma at Trinity College Dublin and master's degree at University College Dublin

**Deutschlandstipendium,** (Scholarship), Nürtingen-Geislingen University — **2019-2021**
300€/month

## SCIENTIFIC PUBLICATIONS

- **Playfulness as a therapeutic resource: From adversity to healing**
  R. Feniger Schaal & T. Constien
  *Handbook of Playfulness (ed. R. Holmes),* in press (expected 2027), Oxford University Press
- ***"I understand more what works":* Evaluating an intervention developed to support dramatherapists in writing their first clinical case study**
  T. Constien, E. Keiller, J. Bourne, M. Willemsen, E. F. Bruun, S. Klees, S. Pendzik
  *The Arts in Psychotherapy,* 2026, DOI: 10.1016/j.aip.2026.102524
- **Pretend Play is not an 'extra': Exploring the relation between parent-reported pretend play and executive functions in the toddlerhood period**
  J. Kelly, T. Constien, M. Downes
  *Cognitive Development,* 2026, DOI: 10.1016/j.cogdev.2026.101759
- **A head taller: A meta-analysis on the relation between pretend play and executive functions**
  T. Constien, S. Moran, B. Rooney, M. Downes
  *Developmental Review,* 2026, DOI: 10.1016/j.dr.2026.101249
- **Client experiences of drama therapy: A systematic review and qualitative meta-analysis**
  T. Constien, A. Khanna, A. Wiberg
  *Qualitative Psychology,* 2025, DOI: 10.1037/qup0000300
- **Facilitators and barriers of dramatherapy for individuals affected by poverty: An instrumental case study**
  Y. Habaal & T. Constien
  *Dramatherapy,* 2025, DOI: 10.1386/dj_00015_1
- **Playfulness in times of extreme adverse conditions: A theoretical model and case illustrations**
  R. Feniger Schaal, T. Constien, H. Orkibi
  *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications,* 2024, DOI: 10.1057/s41599-024-03936-z

- **Open dramatherapy: Embracing Open Science in the further development of our field**
  T. Constien
  *The Dramatherapy Journal,* 2024, DOI: 10.1386/dj_00009_1
- **Drama therapy student research in North America: A narrative review**
  A. Cook, T. Constien, S. Glick, A. Aachen, M. Dominiski & A. Holkesvig
  *GMS Journal of Arts Therapies,* 2024, DOI: 10.3205/jat000035
- **Analysis of the body of literature based on a new drama therapy literature database**
  T. Constien & J. Junker
  *The Arts in Psychotherapy,* 2023, DOI: 10.1016/j.aip.2022.101989

## ALTERNATIVE PUBLICATIONS

**When dads are supported, the whole family benefits** — **2025**
RTÉ Brainstorm, tinyurl.com/FathersDay-Blog

**What's your impact? Mobilising palliative care research through dissemination** — **2024**
European Association for Palliative Care Blog, tab.so/blogpost

## RECENT PRESENTATIONS

**Sleep Europe Congress 2026** — **Oct 2026**
European Sleep Research Society, Maastricht (Netherlands)
- Talk and poster on the moderating role of sleep within the association of toddlers' screen time and emotion regulation.

**10th International Conference on Infant and Early Child Development** — **Aug 2026**
Lancaster University, Lancaster (UK)
- Talk on the role of parental playfulness in toddlers' executive functions development.
- Awarded with an award for the Best Talk.

**Cognitive Development Society Conference** — **Apr 2026**
Cognitive Development Society, Montreal (Canada)
- Poster presentation on a meta-analysis on pretend play and executive functioning.
- Poster presentation on the moderating role of sleep within the association of toddlers' screen time and emotion regulation.

**9th International Conference on Infant and Early Child Development** — **Aug 2025**
Lancaster University, Lancaster (UK)
- Poster presentation on pretend play and executive functioning in the toddlerhood period.

**Annual Psychology Conference** — **Nov 2024**
Psychological Society Ireland, Athlone (Ireland)
- Oral presentation on knowledge and transfer in palliative care research.

**17th European Arts Therapies Conference** — **Sept 2024**
European Consortium of Arts Therapies Education, Ghent (Belgium)
- Oral presentation on playfulness and its role in drama therapy.

For a full list of presentations and talks please see tinyurl.com/TobiasConstien

## PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

**Cognitive Development Society** (CDS)
**UCD Childhood and Human Development Research Centre** (CHilD-RC)
**Children's Research Network** (CRN)
**Scientific Association for the Creative Arts Therapies** (WFKT)